vision' as India embarked upon a determined quest for Independence. With the idea of a post-independent India still undetermined, undefined and unimagined, Bhagat Singh posed a powerful challenge to a pro-capitalist vision of a Gandhi-led Congress Party, as he positioned himself within a solid Indian socialist tradition that posed a simple bipolar choice for the people of India between Gandhian post-imperial capitalism and Bhagat Singh's independent Indian socialism.

This should be contrasted with what became under Gandhi a contest between the Congress Party and the Muslim League or between the Hindus and Muslims (as being their erstwhile Muslim conquerors who had arrived to usurp a long-enduring indigenous culture), which not only led to the formation of a Muslim-dominated Pakistan in 1947, but which also sowed the seeds of discontent within a Hindu-dominated India, with such tensions continuing with increasing ferocity to this day. Pritam Singh maintains that it is entirely possible that had Bhagat Singh lived there would have been a 'large scale migration of the Congress cadre to the fold of the Bhagat Singh-led radical alternative', but unfortunately '[t]hat possibility died with the hanging of Bhagat Singh'. He maintains what many even today will simply not admit: 'Gandhi and the colonial authorities understood the critical historical importance of Bhagat Singh.' This meant that 'Gandhi did not protest against the decision of the colonial authorities to hang Bhagat Singh', and that,

> This decision of Gandhi was not simply the result of the moralist/pacificist Gandhi not endorsing violence because by allowing hanging he was endorsing another kind of violence; it was the result of an extremely sharp tactician and strategist Gandhi realising that if Bhagat Singh survived, that would sound the death knell of his (Gandhi's) political leadership of India's independence movement.

In fact, Bhagat Singh was the only one who stood to threaten Gandhi's hegemony on the political landscape. Gandhi knew that, and if Gandhi, who was not averse to going on a hunger strike, had done the same for Bhagat Singh, it is inconceivable that Lord Irwin, at the time of the three Round Table Conferences between 1930 and 1932, would not have released him!